

running at their full capacity due to the inability of the urban local bodies to provide for full operation and maintenance cost”.

The CPCB's findings about the NRCP's rivers state that most of them have BOD (biochemical oxygen demand) readings that are not in the merely polluted range but in that representing severe toxicity (*see box*). Even though the readings of the CPCB and the CWC are conflicting, experts believe that even in their most poisonous parts, some of India's most famous rivers are merely urban ditches. What makes the matter worse is the construction of dams on various rivers. Noted environmentalist Anupam Mishra says, “We can't stop river pollution until we stop construction of big dams, which was the reason behind the flood in the southern states this year.”

For the rest, time has changed very little, other than the rise in rivers' pollution levels. When the GAP-I was initiated in 1985, the BOD in the Ganga at Kanpur was 6.9mg/litre while the latest sample of CPCB marks it at 21. In 1980, the BOD in the Yamuna at Okhla was 10.6mg/litre, but is now 70. Pollution in the Ganga has gone up three-fold and in the Yamuna by seven

times. The NRCP's files, of course, read perfectly: the programmes include construction of sewage treatment plants, low-cost sanitation works, electric or improved crematoria, river front development and public participation. None of these have been made to work like it should. Every river across India has a sorry story: down south in Chennai, the Cooum and Adayar rivers are famous for industrial pollution. Under the NRCP, Rs 491.52 crore have been sanctioned to clean them while other rivers in the state have been sanctioned Rs 616.17 crore to have particular stretches cleaned. The state's environment council president L. Antonysamy accuses the Chennai endeavour of lack of accountability. “Chennai Metrowater emphasises that only treated sewage is discharged into the water courses. But it is not happening.”

Kerala's Pampa, the lifeline of central Kerala and a water source for 30 lakh people, was included in the first phase of the NRCP in 2003-04 and was slated for cleanup by 2008-09. Today, most of the 11 NRCP projects are under construction and work is yet to begin on the largest one. The state Government moved to set

THE YAMUNA

In Vrindavan, greed is taking concrete shape as pillars are being constructed in the middle of the riverbed as part of a motorable road which will run parallel to the 16th-century ghats



“The scheme of abatement of pollution can't be successful until we stop construction of big dams. Rivers should be allowed to flow naturally to remain unpolluted.”

ANUPAM MISHRA, Environmentalist

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